HINDUSTAN INTERNATIONAL SCHOOL
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Karapakkam

HIS GLOBAL CONCLAVE- EDITION 3.0

"Where Young Minds Meet to Debate, Deliberate and Lead."

UNITED NATIONS HUMAN RIGHTS COUNCIL (UNHRC)

BACKGROUND GUIDE

SDG 11 – Sustainable Cities and Communities

Agenda:

Eradicating Systemic Discrimination Against Indigenous and Minority Populations

Protecting land rights, preserving cultural heritage, and ensuring equal legal protection and political representation for marginalized communities.

Dear *Delegates*,

It is with great pleasure that we welcome you to the Hindustan International School Global Conclave – Edition 3. We are delighted to serve as your Executive Board for this year's **United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC)** and look forward to witnessing your dedication to diplomacy, critical thinking, innovation, meaningful human-rights discourse and solution-oriented debate on November 6.

This year, the committee will deliberate upon the agenda:

"Eradicating Systemic Discrimination Against Indigenous and Minority Populations: Protecting land rights, preserving cultural heritage, and ensuring equal legal protection and political representation for marginalized communities."

This agenda has been carefully selected to encourage delegates to examine the structural and institutional forms of discrimination experienced by Indigenous Peoples and minority communities across the world. While discrimination may appear in different forms, issues surrounding land ownership, displacement, cultural preservation, access to justice, political participation, and equal protection under the law remain significant challenges.

The discussion will also explore how inclusive and sustainable communities can be developed while respecting the identities, traditions, territories, and aspirations of marginalized populations. In this context, **Sustainable Development Goal 11**, particularly its emphasis on inclusive urbanization, participatory planning, and the protection of cultural and natural heritage, provides an important framework for discussion.

We encourage delegates to approach this agenda not merely as a human-rights issue, but as a question of **equity, representation, sustainable development, and social inclusion**.

Your collaboration and diplomacy will be valuable in developing practical and internationally viable solutions. Delegates are encouraged to engage constructively, respecting differing national perspectives, and work towards resolutions that balance human-rights protection with national circumstances and sovereignty.

We look forward to witnessing thoughtful debate, effective diplomacy, and innovative solutions throughout the committee.

Sincerely,

Chairperson & Vice Chairperson

UNHRC

History of the Committee

UNHRC – United Nations Human Rights Council

The **United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC)** is an intergovernmental body within the United Nations system responsible for promoting and protecting human rights around the world.

The Human Rights Council was established by the United Nations General Assembly through **Resolution 60/251 on 15 March 2006**, replacing the former Commission on Human Rights. It held its first meeting on **19 June 2006**. The Council is composed of **47 elected United Nations Member States**, serving three-year terms.

The Council serves as a major international forum for addressing human-rights concerns, examining situations in which human rights may be violated, and promoting universal respect for fundamental freedoms. It also works through mechanisms such as the **Universal Periodic Review (UPR)** and **Special**

Procedures, which allow the international community to examine human-rights situations and thematic issues.

The UNHRC's work encompasses civil, political, economic, social, and cultural rights. It also addresses the rights of vulnerable and marginalized groups, including Indigenous People, national and ethnic minorities, religious minorities, migrants, women, children, and persons with disabilities.

The Council therefore provides an important platform for discussing systemic discrimination and considering how international cooperation can strengthen equality, participation, and protection for communities that have historically experienced marginalization.

Introduction to the Agenda

Eradicating Systemic Discrimination Against Indigenous and Minority Populations

Discrimination against Indigenous and minority populations can extend beyond individual acts of prejudice and become embedded within laws, institutions, policies, and social structures. Such **systemic discrimination** can affect access to land, justice, education, employment, public services, political participation, and cultural expression.

Indigenous Peoples in particular may face displacement from ancestral territories, inadequate recognition of land rights, limited participation in decisions affecting their communities, and threats to traditional languages, customs, and cultural heritage. The United Nations identifies poor political representation and exclusion from decisions concerning Indigenous Peoples' lands as continuing challenges.

Minority communities may similarly experience barriers to effective participation in political and public life. The United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Persons Belonging to National or Ethnic, Religious and Linguistic Minorities emphasizes three important principles: **non-discrimination, effective participation, and protection and promotion of identity**.

Land Rights and Displacement

Land is often closely connected to the **cultural identity, livelihoods, traditions, and spiritual practices** of Indigenous communities. Development projects, resource extraction, infrastructure construction, urban expansion, and environmental pressures can create disputes over ancestral territories.

The challenge for States is to ensure that economic and infrastructure development does not come at the expense of fundamental rights. Meaningful consultation and participation of affected communities are therefore important considerations when decisions concerning their territories are made.

Cultural Heritage and Identity

Cultural heritage includes **languages, traditions, customs, knowledge systems, religious practices, historical sites, art, and traditional ways of life.**

The loss or erosion of cultural heritage can weaken community identity and intergenerational transmission of knowledge. Protecting cultural heritage therefore requires more than preserving physical monuments; it may also involve supporting Indigenous languages, traditional knowledge, cultural institutions, and community-led preservation.

This issue directly connects with **SDG Target 11.4**, which calls upon States to strengthen efforts to **protect and safeguard cultural and natural heritage.**

Equal Legal Protection

Equal protection under the law is a fundamental human-rights principle. The **Universal Declaration of Human Rights**, particularly **Articles 2, 7, and 8**, establishes principles of non-discrimination, equality before the law, and access to effective remedies.

However, legal equality on paper does not necessarily guarantee equality in practice. Barriers such as limited access to courts, language barriers, discriminatory laws or practices, inadequate legal recognition of customary rights, and unequal access to public institutions can prevent marginalized communities from fully exercising their rights.

Political Representation and Participation

Political participation is essential to ensuring that communities have a **voice in decisions that affect them.**

The Universal Declaration of Human Rights recognizes the right of individuals to participate in government and to have equal access to public service.

For Indigenous and minority populations, meaningful participation may require more than formal voting rights. It can involve representation **in legislative institutions, consultation mechanisms, local governance, public**

administration, and decision-making processes concerning land, development, education, and culture.

The international framework on minority rights specifically recognizes the importance of effective participation in **cultural, social, economic, public, national, and regional life.**

Key Treaties and Achievements

Universal Declaration of Human Rights – Adopted on December 10, 1948

The **Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR)** established a common international standard for fundamental human rights.

Its principles of equality, non-discrimination, participation, property rights, cultural participation, and equal protection before the law are directly relevant to the committee's agenda.

Declaration on the Rights of Persons Belonging to National or Ethnic, Religious and Linguistic Minorities – Adopted on December 18, 1992

The Declaration provides an important international framework for protecting minority communities.

It emphasizes the protection of minority identity and recognizes rights relating to culture, religion, language, public life, and effective participation in decisions affecting minority communities.

United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples – Adopted on September 13, 2007

The **United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (UNDRIP)** is one of the most comprehensive international instruments concerning Indigenous rights.

It establishes minimum standards concerning Indigenous Peoples' survival, dignity, well-being, culture, participation, and relationship with their lands and resources. It also emphasizes their participation in decisions affecting their lives and communities.

Sustainable Development Goal 11 – Sustainable Cities and Communities

SDG 11 seeks to make cities and human settlements **inclusive, safe, resilient, and sustainable**.

Target **11.3** focuses on inclusive and sustainable urbanization and participatory planning, while Target **11.4** calls for stronger efforts to protect and safeguard cultural and natural heritage.

These objectives make SDG 11 particularly relevant to questions of minority inclusion, cultural heritage, community participation, and sustainable development.

Human Rights Council Resolution on Human Rights and Indigenous Peoples

The Human Rights Council continues to adopt resolutions addressing the rights of Indigenous Peoples. In **2025, the Council adopted Resolution 60/13 on Human Rights and Indigenous Peoples without a vote**, demonstrating the continued presence of Indigenous rights within the Council's agenda.

Human Rights Council Resolution on the Rights of Persons Belonging to Minorities

The Council also maintains mechanisms dedicated to minority rights. In **March 2026**, the Human Rights Council adopted **Resolution 61/15**, concerning the mandate of the Special Rapporteur on minority issues. The resolution reaffirmed the importance of international human-rights instruments in protecting persons belonging to national or ethnic, religious, and linguistic minorities.

Important Events

1. Adoption of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (1948)

The United Nations General Assembly adopted the UDHR on December 10, 1948. It established universal principles of equality and human dignity that form the foundation of modern international human-rights protection.

2. Adoption of the Declaration on Minority Rights (1992)

The General Assembly adopted the Declaration on the Rights of Persons Belonging to National or Ethnic, Religious and Linguistic Minorities, strengthening international recognition of minority identity, participation, and non-discrimination.

3. Establishment of the Human Rights Council (2006)

The UN General Assembly established the Human Rights Council through Resolution 60/251, replacing the former Commission on Human Rights. The Council subsequently became a central intergovernmental forum for international human-rights discussions.

4. Adoption of the UN Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (2007)

The General Assembly adopted UNDRIP on September 13, 2007. The Declaration established a comprehensive framework addressing the rights, dignity, culture, participation, lands, and development of Indigenous Peoples.

5. Sustainable Development Goals Adopted (2015)

The United Nations adopted the **2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development**, including SDG 11, which calls for inclusive, safe, resilient, and sustainable cities and human settlements.

Target 11.3 emphasizes participatory planning, while Target 11.4 focuses on protecting cultural and natural heritage.

6. Continued UNHRC Action on Indigenous Rights (2025)

The Human Rights Council adopted Resolution 60/13 on human rights and Indigenous Peoples in October 2025, demonstrating the continued relevance of Indigenous rights within the Council's work.

7. Renewal of the Special Rapporteur Mandate on Minority Issues (2026)

In March 2026, the Human Rights Council adopted Resolution 61/15 concerning the Special Rapporteur on minority issues, reaffirming the international community's continuing focus on protecting minority rights.

Closing Remarks

As delegates of the **Hindustan International School Global Conclave Edition 3**, you are entrusted with the responsibility of representing your assigned country and conducting thorough research on the given agenda.

The issue of systemic discrimination against Indigenous and minority populations requires delegates to look beyond individual incidents and examine the structures, policies, and institutions that influence equality and participation.

This committee provides an opportunity to demonstrate your **debating prowess, diplomatic finesse, critical thinking, analytical reasoning, and collaborative**

spirit while addressing questions of land, culture, legal protection, representation, and sustainable development.

Delegates are encouraged to research their country's domestic policies, international commitments, voting patterns, relevant treaties, and relationships with Indigenous and minority communities before entering committee.

We look forward to an engaging, insightful, and solution-driven session.

Good luck, delegates!

Sincerely,

Chairperson & Vice Chairperson

UNHRC